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Political support in a Hausa village

Author(S): Faulkingham, Ralph Harold

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7.1.2.1 The joking relations • 7.1.2.2 Conversation relations.

7.1.2.1 The joking relations

have been formally merged with the Islamic custom of shaaràa, where during the month after Ramadan, a person may demand up to 10CFA from any and each of his matrilineal cross-cousins and his maternal grandparents. Further, one jests deprecatingly with cross cousins and grandparents throughout the year. Analytically, we may say that these joking relations exist between people who have little occasion to come into conflict. Either they live in separate households, or if they live in the same household, their great difference in ages rules out common interests over which they might conflict. While in the abstract, my informants denied that joking relations exist between a person and FaSi and MoBr, their own joking behavior toward these relatives and towards BrSo, BrDa, SiSo, and SiDa contradicted their statements.

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7.1.2.2 Conversation relations.

The hiiraa relations are colored by the juxtaposition of relative age as a determinant of role behavior. Between half and full siblings, there is a great deal of common interest, particularly for the males. Their intimacy in residential and working areas makes the practice of avoidance impossible, and there is the very great possibility (and actuality) of conflict. A mild avoidance is in play which calls for no jesting or accusations, and for the use of the impersonal subject or passive voice in conversations. Also mitigating conflict are the age distinctions. Younger siblings are expected to defer to elder siblings, whether collateral or classificatory. Any older siblings  140 should help younger siblings in bridewealth arrangements. These sibling

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behaviors are extended to parallel cousins; however, the seniority distinction is based on the relative age of the linking relatives (fathers or mothers) regardless of the relative ages of the parallel cousins themselves.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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